

Backend Developer specialized in CRMs &
systematizing business data

Java & SQL

Giuseppe Tavella

It has a name: **petrichor**. But the name is the easy part — what's strange is *why* it exists at all.

Plants, during dry periods, secrete oils into the soil as a way of suppressing seed germination. There's no evolutionary advantage in having competitors sprout when water is scarce. These oils accumulate in clay and rock over weeks. When rain hits, the impact creates tiny air bubbles that burst and launch aerosol droplets carrying those oils into the air.

What you're smelling is essentially **plant chemical warfare**, aerosolized.

There's a second compound involved: **geosmin**, produced by soil bacteria called actinomycetes when they die. Humans can detect geosmin at concentrations as low as 5 parts per trillion — more sensitive than sharks are to blood. No one fully agrees on why we evolved such extreme sensitivity to it. One theory: it helped ancient humans locate water sources from a distance.

The unsettling part is this — **you are smelling death and drought stress**, and evolution made it one of the most universally pleasant scents to humans. What that says about us is unclear.